

MEN'S SKINNY-FAT

LEAN BULKING

MEAL PLANS



**Frequently
Asked Questions**





New Beginnings

Nutrition can either support or sabotage your fitness goals, determining whether you achieve optimal or sub-optimal results. No matter how hard you train, your efforts won't pay off unless you also prioritise your nutrition. This is evident when people put in tremendous effort at the gym but fail to see any progress in their transformation ([I've made this mistake!](#))

Understanding the relationship between nutrition, training, and body composition is crucial for success. Diet controls body composition, while training builds and maintains strength and breaks down muscle mass, forcing the process of muscle repair. Unfortunately, many people misunderstand this connection, focusing solely on burning calories through training, which often leads to a cycle of overtraining and overeating—a lifestyle that is unsustainable and detrimental to your body composition goals.

Contrary to popular belief, you don't need to adhere to a monotonous "bodybuilder" diet of bland foods like grilled chicken and steamed asparagus multiple times a day to achieve fat loss and muscle gain. Such restrictive diets are not sustainable and often result in rebound weight gain.

Instead, I've curated 10 flexible meal plans designed to not only deliver results but also ensure that you'll 'enjoy the process' of lean bulking. These meal plans are formulated to promote muscle building in a consistent manner, making every meal enjoyable and something to look forward to.

I look forward to hearing about your fitness transformation in 12 weeks. Submit your transformation story [here](#).

Let's go!!

Best regards,

Brad

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Q

What is Flexible Dieting?

Flexible dieting embodies a nutritional approach that shouldn't resemble the traditional notion of being 'on a diet.' It revolves around monitoring your intake of macronutrients (protein, carbohydrates, fats) to achieve your desired body composition.

The four main principles of flexible dieting are:

1

How much you eat is more important than *what* you eat.

Your body weight is primarily influenced by your overall caloric intake, rather than specific food choices. While consuming nutritious foods is crucial for overall health and longevity, no single food directly causes weight loss or weight gain. Sugar isn't inherently the enemy, nor are 'healthy fats' automatically the solution to weight management.

2

You should eat foods that you like.

Even if a diet appears flawless in theory, its effectiveness ultimately hinges on whether you can adhere to it. This is why flexible dieting proves invaluable for many people. When I was working night shift, flexible dieting gave me the “freedom” to eat the foods I enjoyed—throughout the night—while hitting my calorie and macronutrient targets.

3

Aim to get 80 to 90% of your calories from nutrient dense food.

Will occasional visits to the drive-thru or pizza place have long-term consequences? Definitely not. However, if done too frequently, you may gradually develop nutritional deficiencies that can contribute to various health issues. [During my own fitness journey](#), I made sure that 80 to 90% of my daily calorie intake, set at 1,900 kcal per day, consisted of nutritious, minimally processed foods.

4

Eat on your schedule.

The timing of your meals isn't as critical as commonly thought. As long as you're meeting your daily calorie and macronutrient goals, when you eat doesn't significantly impact your results. I am testament to this fact. Throughout [my transformation](#), I worked night shifts lasting 12 hours, consuming most of my calories between 8:30 pm and 7:00 am.



Using the Men's Lean Bulking Meal Plans

Q

How to Get the Best Results

If you follow the selected flexible meal plan in this package, *you'll get results*. To ensure your fitness transformation is as streamlined as possible, make sure you do the following:

1

Follow the plan exactly for at least 2 to 3 weeks.

In the initial week of your diet, you may observe a significant increase in weight. This is primarily due to your body storing extra glycogen and water. This underscores the importance of strictly adhering to the plan for two to three weeks, allowing your weight gain to stabilise and enabling you to track it accurately thereafter.

During this period, it's crucial to:

- ▣ Weigh and measure all food in its *raw or dry state*
- ▣ Track and record the intake of *all food*
- ▣ Weigh and calculate all non-liquid food in grams and all liquids in ounces or ml.

2

Weigh yourself daily and calculate weekly averages.

Tracking your body composition is a vital part of your fitness journey.

Learning to measure body composition properly will help you understand exactly what is or isn't happening with your physique, which can help you take corrective actions with your diet and exercise if you're not progressing as you'd like.

This step is crucial and failing to do this will guarantee you'll fail.

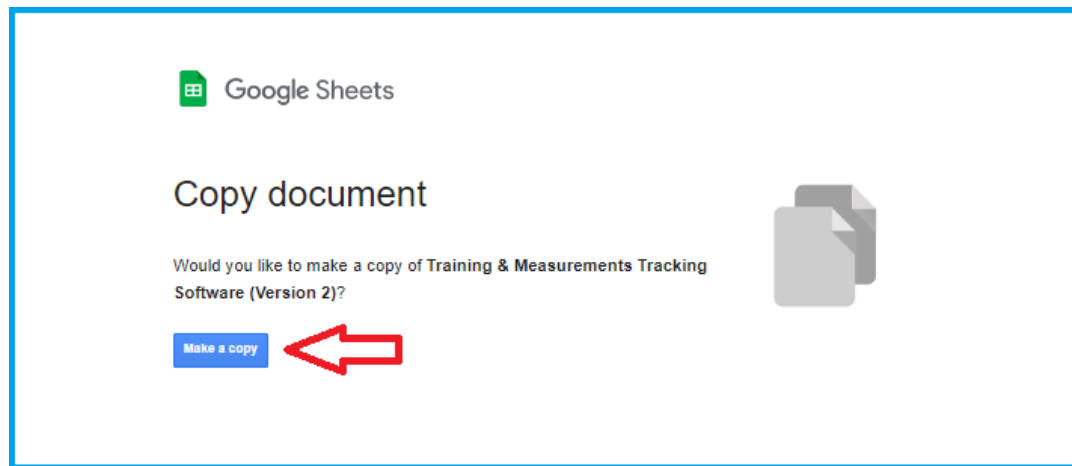


The process is simple:

- Step on the scale first thing in the morning, wearing minimal clothing, after using the bathroom, and before consuming food, beverages, or engaging in any physical training.
- Afterward, at the end of each seven-day period, sum up your last seven weigh-ins and divide the total by seven to determine your average daily weight for the preceding week.
- Document your averages in a readily accessible location, such as Excel, Google Sheets, or the notepad application on your phone.

I've made available, for free, a training and measurements tracking software that you can "copy" across to your Google Drive and record your daily weigh-ins.

You'll need to download the software ([click here](#)) by copying it to your Google Drive. The software is a Google Sheet, and **you must** use a computer or laptop to "make a copy" of it **before** you can access it on your Android or iOS device. When you click on the link, you will see a screen (as below):



[CLICK HERE TO COPY THE TRAINING AND MEASUREMENTS TRACKING SOFTWARE](#)

By strictly adhering to these flexible meal plans, you can anticipate an average *weekly* weight reduction of approximately 0.5 to 1 percent of your total body weight. This signifies that your body is operating under a "negative energy balance," indicating a calorie deficit ranging between 20 to 25 percent.



Should your weight remain stable from week to week, it suggests that your energy expenditure matches your intake, placing your body in a state of "neutral energy balance," resulting in weight maintenance.

Alternatively, if your weight shows an upward trend, it indicates a surplus of energy intake over expenditure, termed a "calorie surplus." This places your body in a state of "positive energy balance," leading to gradual weight gain over time.

Once again, focus on your average weekly weight dropping from week to week and not the *daily* fluctuations! If your weekly average is dropping by around 1 to 2 pounds per week, then you are on the right track. Just be patient and trust the process 😊

3 Take weekly body measurements.

Relying solely on weighing yourself can't accurately indicate whether you're gaining or losing fat—it merely reflects overall weight changes. That's why it's important to regularly track at least *one* additional body measurement each week—your ***waist circumference***.

To measure your waist circumference:

- ❑ Wrap a tape measure around your bare stomach at your navel (strive to measure at the same spot each time). You can buy a cheap tape measure from [here](#).
- ❑ Ensure the tape measure is parallel to the ground (not tilted) and snug against your body, avoiding excessive tightness that might compress the skin.
- ❑ Exhale naturally while taking the measurement and maintain a relaxed posture without flexing or sucking in your stomach.

Here's an example of me taking waist measurements using a tape measure around the navel area (at or near the belly button).



My training and measurements software ([download from here](#)) will allow you to enter in your measurements every week. See screenshot below.

MEASUREMENTS TRACKER									SELF CHECK-IN NOTES											
Target Calories	Waist	Hip	OPTIONAL					Estimated BF %	(i.e., what happened during the week?)											
			Neck	Chest	Thigh	Bicep	Calf													
2100	93.0	85.0	93.0	85.0	93.0	93.0	85.0	27.0	Felt great, strong in the gym and love the new training plan											

If you enjoy monitoring data and quantifying progress like me, you can also measure other body parts such as your chest, neck, thigh, biceps, and calves.

4 Take monthly body fat measurements

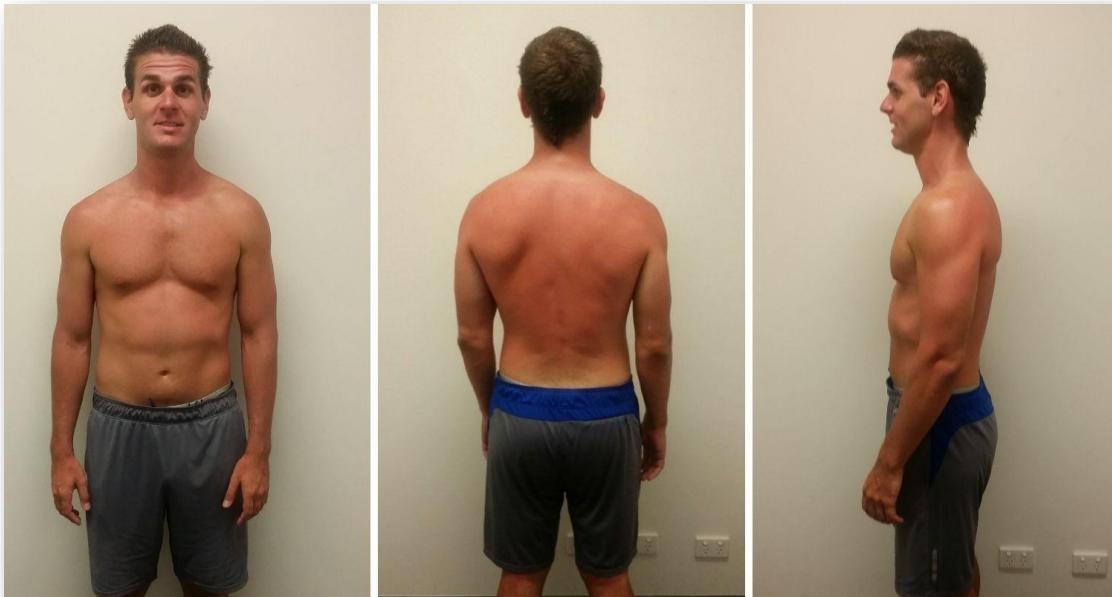
To get an even better understanding of how your body composition is changing, use a body fat calliper to take skinfold measurements every month and record the results inside of [my training and measurements tracking software](#).

5 Take bi-weekly progress pictures.

While numerical data from measurements is valuable, our primary concern lies in the visual changes we observe in the mirror. That's why regularly capturing progress pictures is crucial—they provide a visual timeline of your transformation. Here's how to do it effectively:



- Take pictures from the front, side, and back, revealing as much skin as you're comfortable with (optimal exposure enhances the clarity of body changes).
- Ensure consistency by using the same camera, lighting, and background for all photos.
- Take the pictures at the same time every day, preferably in the morning, after using the bathroom and before breakfast.
- Take both flexed and unflexed pictures, as this lets you see how your muscles are developing.
- Double check each picture to make sure they're clear and free from any glare or shadow that might make it difficult to see your body.



Q

What should I do if my weight loss slows down or stops?

The most frequent complaints I receive from guys through my website is sluggish weight loss progress or weight loss plateaus. Despite the complex nature of human metabolism, overcoming weight loss plateaus is not as difficult as it may seem.

If you notice your weight loss progress slowing down or coming to a halt, it's essential to ensure you're not falling into one of the following pitfalls.

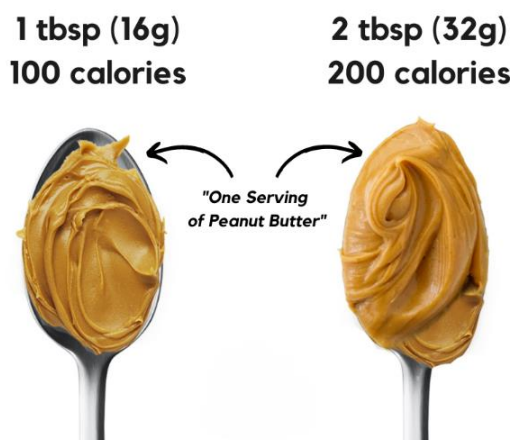


1 Not following the meal plan!

You may believe that occasional deviations from your meal plan won't significantly impact your progress, but that assumption is *wrong*!

Adhering strictly to your plan entails:

- ❑ Avoiding additional snacking between meals that's outside of the meal plan.
- ❑ Refraining from making unplanned changes or additions to meals or snacks. This includes altering the cooking oil or butter and adding extra sauces or dressings. You'd be surprised how many *hundreds* of extra calories can fly under the radar when they are not accounted for.
- ❑ Ensuring all substitutions are accurately measured (i.e., heaped tablespoons vs level tablespoons!). Yes, it makes a big difference!



- ❑ Abstaining from eyeballing or estimating ingredients or portions—every item consumed should be precisely weighed and recorded. You must use a [digital food scale](#) for precision.

2 Not tracking and logging body measurements.

Regularly monitoring your progress, or lack thereof, and quantifying it with concrete numbers is crucial to determining whether you're on the right path. Failure to consistently track changes in your body can lead you into a rut.

I've seen this time and time again with my [coaching clients](#) that “forget” to log their daily weigh-ins in the tracking spreadsheet. The only way we can be assured you are moving in the right direction is to accurately measure and record your measurements.



Below is a recent client example where they've tracked their fluctuating daily weight, but their *average weekly weight* change is decreasing from week to week. You should only care about how the **weekly average** moves (i.e., increase for a bulk or decreasing for a cut) rather than daily weigh-ins.

	Week	Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun	Average Weekly Weight	Weight Change
1	13-Nov-2023		166.4	167.0	166.2		166.6		166.6	-0.95
2	20-Nov-2023	167.4	166.6	166.8	165.8	167.6	167.4	166.6	166.9	0.34
3	27-Nov-2023	165.6	165.6	165.2	165.6	165.4	165.6	164.8	165.4	-1.15
4	4-Dec-2023	164.6	163.8	163.6	162.0	163.0	162.8	162.6	163.2	-2.20
5	11-Dec-2023	163.0	162.6	162.6	161.6	161.6	160.4	160.6	161.8	-3.63
6	18-Dec-2023	160.0	160.8	159.6	160.0	159.2	159.8	159.8	159.9	-1.89
7	25-Dec-2023	160.4	160.6	160.4			159.4	159.0	160.0	-1.81
8	1-Jan-2024	157.8	157.8	157.4	157.6	157.4	157.2	157.6	157.5	-2.42
9	8-Jan-2024	158.4	157.0						157.7	-2.26

Monitoring changes in your body involves:

- Daily weigh-ins with weekly average calculations
- Weekly waist measurements
- Monthly body fat measurements

3 Too many “cheat meal” mistakes.

The 5 biggest cheat meal mistakes you can make are:

- Cheating too frequently.
- Eating too much in a cheat meal (exceeding 150% of your current target in a cheat meal)
- Indulging in cheat days, not meals.
- Eating too much dietary fat.
- Drinking too much alcohol.



Q

Can I drink alcohol?

Certainly, but as a rule of thumb, minimising alcohol consumption tends to yield better results. Throughout my years of offering [online coaching](#), I frequently encounter questions from potential clients like, "Brad, I aim to achieve a shredded physique, but can I still enjoy red wine?"

In small amounts—just one or two drinks per day—offers potential health benefits such as [improved insulin sensitivity](#), [cardiac function](#), and [blood lipid levels](#). Lowering these lipids reduces the risk of heart disease.

However, we are all aware that on the other hand, excessive drinking can lead to situations where you can barely recall how you made it home from the club!

The [scientific evidence](#) is clear regarding the muscle-wasting effects of consuming large quantities of alcohol. If your recollection of encounters from the previous night is hazy, it's likely to hinder your muscle-building efforts. Additionally, it's widely acknowledged that alcohol consumption can diminish strength and hinder the body's ability to repair muscle damage.

If you find it necessary to consume alcohol, limit yourself to a maximum of 200 to 300 calories of alcohol *per week*. Ensure that this intake is accounted for within your flexible meal plan.

If you want to be able to drink and still lose weight efficiently, follow these guidelines:

- Don't drink more than one day per week.
- Restrict your dietary fat intake on days you have a drink, and don't eat any high-fat foods while you're drinking.
- Stay away from carb-laden drinks like beer and fruity stuff (stick to dry wines and spirits).



Q

What should I expect from using the meal plans?

When aiming to shred fat, aim to lose approximately 0.5 to 1 percent of your total body weight per week.

If you're dieting to lean bulk, you should look to gain about 0.5 to 1 percent of your total body weight per week. If you're new to weightlifting, you may be able to gain as much as 1 to 1.5 percent of your total body weight per week.

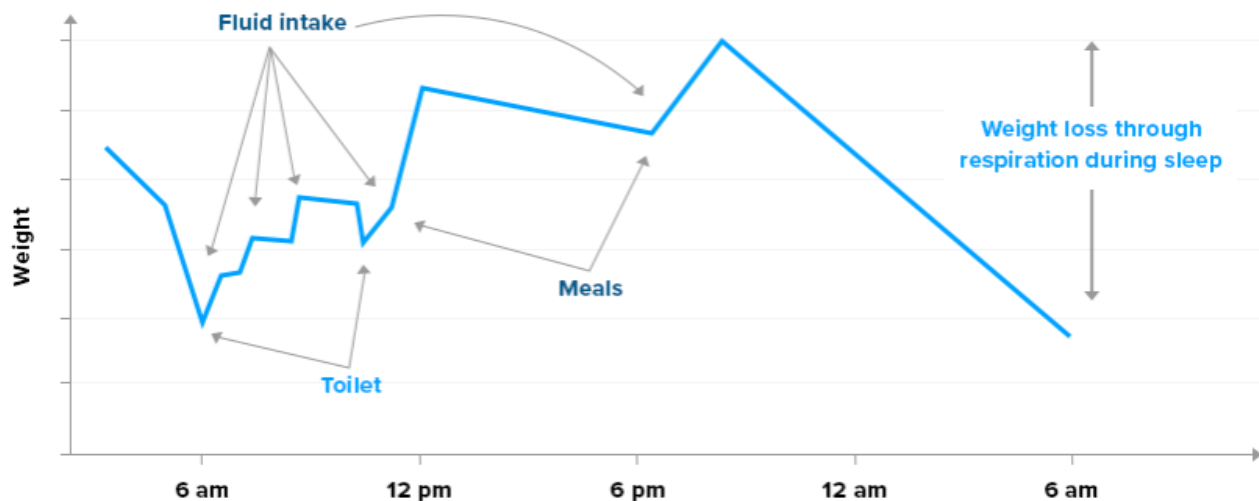
For weight maintenance, your average weight should remain relatively stable week to week.

If you're looking to maintain your current weight, your average weight should stay about the same from week to week.

According to research, your average daily weight can fluctuate by **2 to 5 pounds**.

The beginning of the day presents the lowest weight point, rising gradually throughout the day as meals and beverages are consumed. For a visual representation, check out the graph below:

Weight Fluctuations Over A 24-hour Period





Q What sort of weightlifting and cardio routine should I be doing?

An effective training routine generally involves:

- ▣ Three to five one-hour weightlifting sessions per week; **and**,
- ▣ One to three 20-to-30-minute high-intensity cardio sessions per week **or**
- ▣ Two to three 30-to-40-minute low-intensity cardio sessions per week.

When it comes to weightlifting, the training method that I deployed as a skinny-fat guy to get absolutely shredded, while working an insane night shift roster, was Push Pull Legs (PPL).

This training split targets nearly every muscle group in the body, aiming for comprehensive muscle development where each day of the week is dedicated to training specific muscle groups: upper-body pushing muscles (push), upper-body pulling muscles (pull), or the entire lower body (legs).

If you are absolutely brand new to lifting, I suggest 3 days per week of weight training, where you train push, pull, and legs! Keep it simple 😊

To learn more about the push-pull-legs system, check out my book below:

- ▣ [Push Pull Legs: The Ultimate Beginner Guide](#)

Cardio is *not necessary* for getting shredded (which surprises many people). Personally, I only introduce cardio into my regimen for cutting if I am trying to get into single digits of body fat. The best way to include cardio while you are in a cutting phase is to do as little as required to reach your desired rate of weight loss, remain fit and happy, and no more.

If you are not able to include cardio into your regimen during a cut, then don't despair. Provided you are hitting your daily calorie and macronutrient targets—without cardio—you will still lose fat.

However, implementing 2 to 3 hours of low intensity cardio *per week* can help speed up fat loss. Here are several methods that I like to deploy when I'm implementing cardio during my cutting phases—and typically *after* my weightlifting sessions, or on separate days.



- High-Intensity Interval Training (HIIT). This allows you to keep your cardio sessions short and intense. Personally, I incorporate no more than 15 to 20 minutes of HIIT per session, 2 to 3 times per week, during my cutting phase. Alternatively, I may opt for low intensity cardio (next method.)
- Low-Intensity Steady-state Cardio (LISS). This may consist of 40 to 60 minutes per session of rowing, assault bike, jogging, skip rope, rucking, or walking. I would aim to get 2 to 3 hours per week of LISS (absolute maximum). I usually program low intensity cardio on my “rest days” from weightlifting to minimise fatigue and allow most of my energy to be invested into weightlifting. Sometimes I incorporate LISS (over HIIT) if I need to catch up on podcasts 😊

Try to implement your cardio and weightlifting sessions on *separate* days. If you can only do them on the same day, separate them by *at least 8 hours* (if you are doing a split gym session.) If you can only do them in the same gym session, then do your cardio workout *after* your weightlifting session.

If you are an absolute beginner, then I only suggest trying to add small amounts of HIIT into your routine during a cutting phase. Personally, I would start with low intensity cardio and slowly build-up to HIIT due to the physiological stress HIIT can cause on your body. If you don't incorporate HIIT then it's not a problem, the [research shows](#) that it's no more effective for weight loss than low intensity cardio.

Condiment Swapping Guide

If you don't like the condiment options given in your meal plan, use the Condiment Swapping Guide on the second page of your meal plan PDF to find nutritionally similar alternatives that you can use instead.

Shopping Lists

As an added bonus, we've included shopping lists containing the amount of food you need to buy for each plan if you want to prep food:

- One day at a time.
- Every five days, so you can prep all your weekday meals.
- Every six days, so you can prep all your weekday meals, plus one “cheat meal” day.
- Every seven days, so you can prep all your meals for the entire week on one day.



Adjusting the Meal Plans

Q I don't like one of the food/meal/snack options, or I want to eat something that isn't on any of the meal plans—how do I adjust the plan to fit my tastes?

Feel free to swap foods, meals, and snacks out for things you prefer, as long as the calories and macros of the food you want to eat match what's in the plan.

If you need to find the calories and macros of a particular food, use either the [FoodData Central](#) website, or [CalorieKing](#). I also use the food database inside MyNetDiary or MyFitnessPal, which are free apps you can download onto your phone.

Q I'm really new to meal planning—how do I match the calorie and macro targets?

Ensuring you hit your daily calorie target is essential for achieving your weight loss or weight gain goals as planned.

This means that if you add calories to one of your meals, you must also subtract the same number of calories from one of your other meals on that day.

For example, suppose you have a protein shake in the morning and decide to use 100 calories of whole milk instead of water as indicated in your plan. In that case, you'll need to reduce the calorie intake of one of your other meals (lunch, dinner, or pre-bed snack) by 100 calories to maintain your daily calorie target.

The same principle applies to protein intake. Whether you're aiming to build muscle during bulking or maintain muscle during cutting, meeting your daily protein target is crucial. If you don't consume enough protein in one of your meals, you'll need to compensate by consuming more protein in another meal.

It's important to note that not all sources of protein contain the same number of calories. For instance, 30 grams of protein from turkey breast contains around 150 calories, while the same amount of protein from sirloin steak contains around 200 calories, and from eggs about 350 calories. Therefore, if you switch the protein source in one of your meals from turkey to sirloin steak, you'll need to adjust your calorie intake elsewhere accordingly.



However, when it comes to carbohydrates and fats, the rules are not as strict. As long as you meet your daily protein target and don't exceed your daily calorie limit, you have the flexibility to distribute the remaining calories between carbs and fats based on your preferences.

Nevertheless, it's still advisable to aim for the recommended carbohydrate and fat targets provided in your plan. Doing so will ensure that your meals are satisfying, enjoyable, and provide ample energy for your workouts.

Q

Which brands of food should I buy?

Buy the brands you like.

That said, some brands' foods contain more or less calories than others', so take a look when choosing and go with what fits most closely to the numbers given on the plan. So long as your actual caloric intake is within about 50 calories of the meal plan's target, you'll be fine.

If you prefer a brand that has significantly different calorie and macro totals to what's on your plan, make sure you account for the difference by adding or subtracting as necessary to hit your daily calorie/macro targets (given at the bottom of the plans). For example, let's say the plan you're using says:

	Cals	Protein	Carbs	Fat
2 slices whole grain bread	217	11	35.5	3.5

So, [Arnold® 100% Whole Wheat bread](#) would fit that very nicely. [Dave's Killer Bread 21 Whole Grains and Seeds](#) matches fairly closely, too.

However, if you prefer [Breadsmith Brioche Bread](#) (at 140 calories per slice, for a total of 280 calories—60 calories more than what is given on the plan) you'd have to take those calories out from another meal.

If you prefer Nature's Own® 100% Whole Grain Bread (at 70 calories per slice), you will have to add in the difference (2 slices makes 140 calories, which is 80 calories less than what is given on the plan).



In this case, the answer could be as simple as having 3 slices of bread.

	Cals	Protein	Carbs	Fat
3 slices Nature's Own® 100% Whole Grain Bread	210	12	36	4.5

. . . Or adding roughly 80 calories of carbs to a different meal.

Q What can I use instead of butter or oil to grill or sauté my food?

I suggest cooking spray.

Keep in mind, though, that these sprays are only “zero calorie” if you press the button for a quarter of a second, so be careful not to use too much.

Q Should I eat differently on the days that I don't exercise?

If you're in a phase of cutting or maintaining, you don't need to alter your diet on non-exercise days.

Ensure that on rest days or non-lifting days, you still consume meals designated as 'pre-' and 'post-workout' as they provide a significant portion of your daily protein intake.

For those bulking who find consuming large quantities of food daily exhausting, consider reducing calorie intake by approximately 10-20% on rest days. However, if you feel comfortable, stick to the established eating plan.



Q

Does how I cook the food matter?

No, it's up to your preference! Cook it however you like.

However, avoid adding extra oil or butter during cooking, as this adds unaccounted-for calories.

Personally, I use zero-calorie olive oil or coconut oil spray. Keep in mind that these sprays are truly 'zero calorie' only if sprayed for a quarter of a second, so exercise caution to avoid excessive use.

If you find you need more than a quick spritz (which is likely to coat a pan adequately), consider each spray as 10 calories and 1 gram of fat.

Q

How do I adjust the plan to fit my preferred workout schedule?

You don't have to work out at the time given in your meal plan, but you may have to move your meals and snacks around a little if you prefer to work out at a different time of day.

For example, if the plan has your workout in the evening (before dinner with a pre-workout shake) but you would prefer to work out after lunch, have lunch 1 to 2 hours before working out (as your pre-workout meal), and then have the meal marked "Pre-Workout Shake" after you work out.

And voilà, you've modified the "Before Dinner Workout" plan to an "After Lunch Workout" plan!



Pre- and Post-Workout Nutrition

One of the first things most people learn about when they start working out and taking their diet seriously is pre- and post-workout nutrition.

You may have heard that if you don't eat protein and carbs immediately before and after training, you're missing an opportunity to accelerate muscle growth, if not directly hinder it.

In reality, pre- and post-workout nutrition isn't as crucial as many would have us believe—so long as you're eating enough calories every day and your macros are set up properly, when you eat isn't going to make or break your gains.

Once those things are taken care of, though, optimising when you eat can help you build muscle faster.

Q

Should I eat protein before a workout?

It depends.

If you haven't eaten protein in the 3 to 4 hours preceding your workout, then it's a good idea to eat 30 to 40 grams or so before you train.

If you have eaten protein in the last few hours, though, then you don't need to eat more. You can just eat after your workout.

Q

Should I eat carbs before a workout?

Yes.

Research shows that eating carbs before you train improves performance.

For our purposes, 30 to 40 grams of any type of carbohydrate eaten about 30 minutes before a workout will get the job done.



Q Should I eat fat before a workout?

You can, but you don't need to—current research shows it won't benefit your performance in the gym.

Q Should I eat protein after a workout?

Yes.

Eating protein stimulates muscle protein synthesis regardless of when you eat it but eating it after a workout amplifies these effects.

That's why I generally recommend eating 30 to 40 grams of protein an hour or two after you work out.

Q Should I eat carbs after a workout?

Probably.

Adding carbs to your post-workout meal replenishes glycogen stores and keeps insulin levels elevated for longer, which is desirable from a muscle-building standpoint because insulin suppresses muscle breakdown rates.

Eating 20 to 40 grams should do the trick, and leave you enough left over to make other meals that day balanced and enjoyable.

Q Should I eat fat after a workout?

Sure, if you want to—there's no benefit, but there's nothing wrong with it either.



Q

Should I eat some protein before bed?

Consuming protein before bed isn't essential for making significant progress in muscle and strength development, but scientific research indicates its beneficial.

Optimal sources of pre-bed protein include cooked egg or casein protein due to their slow digestion rate, ensuring a sustained release of amino acids into the bloodstream throughout sleep.

If considering a pre-bed protein intake, aim for approximately 30 to 40 grams from either egg or casein sources. For egg protein, options include whole eggs, egg whites, or protein powder. Similarly, for casein, choices include cottage cheese, Greek yogurt, or casein powder. I personally recommend [Optimum Nutrition Casein powder](#).

Q

What is fasted training?

During the digestion and absorption phase of consumed food, your body enters a "fed" or "postprandial" state (where "prandial" refers to meal-related activities).

After completion of this process, typically occurring within 3 to 6 hours after eating (although duration may vary based on meal composition), insulin levels decline to a minimum or baseline level. At this point, your body transitions into a "fasted" or "postabsorptive" state.

Exercise conducted during periods of low insulin levels and cessation of food absorption constitutes "fasted" training.

While fasted training doesn't inherently increase calorie burn compared to fed cardio, it may enhance fat burning, particularly when combined with appropriate supplements.



Q

How do I implement fasted training into my routine?

Fasted training involves exercising when your body has ceased food processing, and insulin levels are at a low, baseline level.

For many people, this entails working out in the morning before consuming any food.

However, if morning workouts aren't feasible or preferable, ensure a gap of approximately 5 or 6 hours after eating before training.

This allows ample time for your body to complete the digestion of the last meal and for insulin levels to normalise.

While fasted training offers unique advantages, it also presents drawbacks. Notably, it significantly elevates muscle breakdown rates, which, though not catastrophic, can impede muscle gain, especially considering the challenges of natural muscle development.

The undesirable consequence of excessive muscle cell damage during workouts is evident: compromised repair processes lead to diminished muscle growth over time, or potentially even muscle loss.

Q

Should I do fasted training if I'm bulking?

No! And here's why...

Firstly, during a bulking phase, your main objective is to maximise muscle growth. To achieve this efficiently, it's recommended to consume approximately 1 gram of protein per pound of body weight per day, divided into 4 to 6 smaller servings spaced a few hours apart.

If there's been a gap of 3 to 4 hours without protein consumption before your workout, your body's protein synthesis rates are likely to be at a baseline level.

(Muscle protein synthesis, incidentally, refers to the process wherein your body repairs muscle fibres.)

Essentially, during periods of inactivity in this process, your muscle-building mechanisms remain dormant, awaiting the next intake of protein to kick-start them into action.



Any instance where your muscle-building mechanisms are idle equates to lost repair time. Instead of actively building muscle, your body is left waiting for fuel.

Moreover, if you proceed with a workout several hours after your last meal, you prolong this inactivity in your muscle-building machinery. Delaying post-workout nutrition could lead to breakdown rates surpassing synthesis rates, resulting in muscle loss.

Hence, during a bulking phase, consuming protein before training, especially if it has been a while since your last protein intake, is advisable. This kick-starts muscle-building processes and may enhance the anabolic response to training.

The second reason to avoid fasted training during bulking is to avoid lacklustre training sessions.

Many people experience diminished energy and focus when training in a fasted state, leading to lower levels of physical and mental intensity than usual. Consistently subpar workouts ultimately translate to significantly reduced muscle gains during a bulking phase, a situation easily rectified by ensuring proper pre-workout nutrition.



Troubleshooting

Q

I'm not losing weight—what should I do?

The first thing you should ask is are you losing fat but not weight?

The primary culprit behind this phenomenon is often fluid retention, a common occurrence among individuals, particularly women, who are biologically predisposed to retaining fluids, exacerbated by hormonal fluctuations such as those occurring during menstrual cycles.

The mechanism is straightforward: while shedding a pound of fat per week, an additional pound of water may be retained. Though the ratio may vary, this can result in minimal perceived fat loss or even weight gain during weigh-ins.

Fortunately, addressing water retention issues is generally straightforward. It typically involves maintaining a balance between sodium and potassium intake, adequate hydration, and managing cortisol levels effectively.

If water retention isn't the issue, the next consideration is whether you're new to weightlifting.

For newcomers, simultaneous fat loss and muscle gain are common, with the latter contributing to increased weight. These initial muscle gains, often referred to as "newbie gains," can lead individuals new to weightlifting and proper dieting to anticipate a lack of weight loss for the first 3 to 6 weeks.

During this period, monitoring weight is important, but waist measurement proves to be a more reliable indicator of fat loss progress. A shrinking waistline indicates fat loss irrespective of scale readings.

If neither water retention nor novice weightlifting status explains the lack of weight loss, it's time to consider one of two options:

- 1 Eat less
- 2 Move more



Many people immediately go for #1 because it's "easier" to just eat less than exercise more, but further calorie restriction shouldn't be your default choice.

Instead, try to "max out" on exercise first because this allows you to kickstart your fat loss while staving off the negative side effects associated with dieting. It also tends to produce better long-term results.

Q

I'm not gaining weight—what should I do?

If you're trying to "bulk," but your body weight hasn't increased in several weeks, chances are you're just not eating enough calories.

Don't increase intake willy-nilly, though. Here's how you do it right.

- 1** Keep your protein at 1 gram per pound of body weight.
There's no need to eat more than this.
- 2** Increase your daily calorie intake by 100 to 150 calories by increasing carbohydrate intake. That is, add 25 to 35 grams of carbs to your daily intake.
- 3** If, after 7 to 10 days, your weight is still the same, repeat #2.
Increase daily carb intake repeatedly until you're gaining weight at the desired rate.

It's really that simple.

Some people, however, (guys usually) need to eat downright gluttonous amounts of food to gain weight steadily.

In this case it's not exactly feasible to reach their necessary calorie levels by increasing carbohydrate intake alone. In such cases, cap carbs at about 3 grams per pound and, if more calories are needed, start increasing fat intake instead.



Q

I'm hungry—what can I do?

The primary objective of your body is to maintain an energy equilibrium—it aims to consume energy equal to what it expends. Being in an energy deficit is not its preferred state.

This is why, when you're on a weight loss diet, you often contend with hunger. Unfortunately, this can make the process of dieting quite challenging.

However, succumbing to your natural instincts and consuming more than planned can easily derail your weight loss efforts. Even a slight overindulgence in calorie-dense foods during meals can negate the deficit and impede your progress. I usually spend quite a bit of time with my [coaching clients](#), teaching them how to manage these slight hunger cravings.

Hence, managing hunger effectively is crucial during a calorie deficit. Fortunately, there are several simple strategies you can employ to curb hunger and cravings, including:

- ▣ Eat slowly—take your time, chew your food, and enjoy each bite
- ▣ Drink a couple of glasses of water with each meal
- ▣ Supplement with 5-HTP

Fun fact: one of the strategies I deployed myself when I was undertaking my own transformation was using a smaller spoon to eat my oats! By doing this, I felt like my oats could last longer 😊

Q

I've been doing this *forever*—when will I be able to see my abs?

Let's face it, acquiring a sculpted set of six-pack abs is a goal that most of us want to achieve. Most of us also know that to achieve this, we need to strip off the excess fat that's covering our abs by focusing on our diet.

And you'll have to do this until you reduce your body fat percentage, depending on your gender. For men, it's at least around 10-12% body fat until you start to "see" your abs. For women, it's around 14-18% body fat.



Q

Should I cut or bulk?

The answer depends mostly on your current body fat percentage.

You should cut if...

- ▣ You're currently unhappy with your body fat percentage and you really just want to get lean before worrying about gaining significant amounts of muscle.
- ▣ You're a man with 15+% body fat.
- ▣ You're a woman with 25+% body fat.

And you should bulk if you want to maximise muscle gain and you don't mind gaining some fat, and...

- ▣ You're a man at or around 10-15% body fat.
- ▣ You're a woman at or around 20% body fat.

Q

I've finished my bulk and want to cut back to a lower body fat percentage—what should I do?

To start a shred, this is what you need to do:

- 1 Use an aggressive (but not reckless) calorie deficit of about 20 to 25 percent.
- 2 Eat a high-protein and high-carb diet.
- 3 Do a lot of heavy, compound weightlifting.
- 4 Keep your cardio to a minimum.
- 5 Take supplements proven to accelerate fat loss (optional).



Take a look at these articles for more information on how to get shredded:

- ▣ [Push Pull Legs: The Ultimate Beginner Guide](#)
- ▣ [The Best Macronutrient Calculator](#)

Q

I've reached my goal weight/body composition/physique—what should I do?

Congratulations and well done for sticking with it!

Here's one of the great things about being in great shape: It's much easier to stay fit than it is to get there in the first place.

Simply continue to track your calorie intake and body measurements (to make sure you're truly maintaining, and not slipping into a calorie deficit, or more commonly, a calorie surplus), and adjust your training to suit your new goals.

Q

I still don't like the way I look—what should I do?

Generally, people don't like their physiques for two reasons:

- 1 They have too much fat covering and obscuring their muscle definition.
- 2 They don't have enough muscle in the right places.

To remedy these issues, you need to either:

- 1 Cut until you're at the body fat percentage you're more comfortable with
- 2 Bulk until you have the amount of muscle in the places you want



In my experience coaching guys for almost 10 years, most guys will need to cut and bulk several times before arriving at their ideal physique. And no, you do not need to take any steroids! I've helped thousands of guys get shredded by simply combining correct dieting (i.e., tracking calories and macros), with a structured lifting program.

Q

What is the best way to get the physique/body composition I want?

The best way to reach your physique and body composition goals is to follow a solid training program and juggle your bulks and cuts until you've gained the size you want. To learn more about how to achieve this, watch [my fitness transformation video](#) where I share with you how to diet and train correctly.

Q

Can I build muscle and lose fat at the same time?

It depends.

You can definitely build muscle and lose fat simultaneously (also known as “body recomposition”) when you're new to weightlifting, but your ability to “recomp” grows smaller and smaller as you approach your genetic potential for muscle gain.

If you're an experienced lifter, you'll be much better served by the more traditional cycle of “lean bulking” and “cutting” to get the physique you want.

I wrote an article on this subject, check it out here:

- ▣ [Body Recomposition for Beginner's](#)



Q Why are the daily totals different from the daily targets?

Some days the totals and targets won't add up exactly, but this isn't cause for concern—it just means that we had to make a calculated concession so your food tastes good. The discrepancies are normally negligible, too, and won't make a marked difference to your progress.

Q The carb total is 20+ grams higher than the target—what gives?

You might have noticed that on some days, the carb total on your plan is higher than the target, even though the calorie target and total match up. This is due to the types of carbs in items like Quest Bars, and Halo Top.

You see, not all carbs are created equal.

Without getting too bogged down in the nitty gritty, most types of carbohydrate contain about 4 calories per gram, though some contain fewer.

Specifically, insoluble fiber contains no calories, soluble fiber contains about 2 calories per gram, and erythritol contains about 0.2 calories per gram.

The carb targets and totals in your plan take all of this into account and are adjusted accordingly, which can make for slightly lopsided numbers, but it's nothing to worry about.

Q Should I be “eating back” the calories I burn every day?

Don't eat back your calories. If you “eat back” your calories while in a calorie deficit for fat loss, then you'll be thrown out of a calorie deficit. Likewise, eating back your calories while in a calorie surplus for building muscle will create a larger surplus leading to a disproportionate increase in fat gain over muscle.



There are exceptions to the rule. If you are in a calorie deficit with your target calories set to, for example, 2,000 calories per day—assuming 4 to 5 hours of training per week—then eating back some calories would be necessary if you've undertaken more training than planned.

Likewise, if you've set your target calories for bulking at, for example, 3,500 calories—assuming 4 to 5 hours of training per week—would require that you eat back calories if you've decided to do an extra 3 hours of kickboxing training for the week. In this scenario, failing to eat back your calories will mean the excess cardio would throw you out of a calorie surplus and into a deficit (not ideal if you are trying to bulk.)

To keep it simple. While you are following the flexible meal plan template, stick to meeting your total daily calorie and macronutrient obligations, and set training regimen. Only make tweaks and changes to your meal plan template or training regimen if you've plateaued (discussed later.)

Q

Should I bulk or cut first? I'm confused...

This is quite easily one of the most common questions I receive. This question usually comes from people that are struggling with a “skinny fat” physique (a problem I once had—[watch my skinny fat transformation story here.](#))

The answer is relatively straightforward. Ask yourself these two questions.

1. What is your **main goal** right now?
2. What is your current approximate body fat percentage?

If your main goal is to gain more size, more strength, and set personal bests in the gym, then provided your body fat percentage is hovering around 10 to 13% (for guys,) I would suggest start with a bulking phase. If your body fat percentage is over 20% (for guys) then start with a cutting phase until you reach 10 to 13% then reassess.

If your main goal is to get shredded, see a six pack and muscle definition—maybe due to an upcoming wedding or special event—then I'd suggest starting with the cutting phase.



Keep in mind that most people will usually need two proper bulk/cut cycles to completely realise their physique dreams. No matter whether you choose to bulk, cut, or do a “body re-composition” (discussed later,) you’ll eventually reach the end goal of a strong, lean, and muscular physique.

Don’t overthink this process. Deciding on whether you should bulk or cut first is negligible. It’s more important to focus on hitting your daily target and macronutrient needs, learning how to lift in the gym, being patient, and trusting the process. If you apply these ingredients, your body will transform.

Q

What if I over-eat or have an outright binge session?

The slippery slope of mainstream dieting that we have all fallen into looks like this.

Overly restrictive, very low-calorie diets lead to cravings. Cravings lead to “cheating.” Cheating leads to binge-eating and binge-eating leads to quitting.

Therefore, the flexible dieting approach is so effective because it utilises the ideology of removing all the psychological burden associated with dietary restrictions. The only “restriction” of flexible dieting is ensuring you do not exceed your daily calorie and macronutrient targets. However, there will be times when you will have to attend weddings, birthdays, travel for work, or other commitments that go against your “well designed” flexible meal plan. Or perhaps you decided to smash the entire block of chocolate on a Friday night instead of the three squares you originally planned for in the flexible meal plan.

This binge-eating spree may have rolled over into the following day where you’ve completely over-eaten days’ worth of excess calories—gaining fat and looking bloated.

Does that mean you’ve completely failed? Absolutely not! Even with my own flexible meal plans, I’ve had moments of all-out late-night binge eating. My strategy is to wake up the next day and start from scratch and forget about yesterday.



Online Fitness Coaching Services

Have you tried everything to lean bulk or shred belly fat, build muscle, and get stronger, but nothing seems to work?

Are you a skinny-fat guy and not sure whether you should bulk or cut first?

Have you watched dozens of YouTube videos, read a gazillion articles, listened to countless podcasts, or queried ChatGPT, but still unsure exactly how to put all the pieces together?

Or maybe you know what to do and just need someone to hold you accountable and keep you on track when you start doubting yourself.

Would you rather have an expert lead you through your transformation journey—cut out all the noise and confusion—and just give you everything you need to build your best physique ever? (even if you've tried and failed before).

If so, our proven science-based VIP one-on-one coaching service will give you the motivation and certainty you need to get results faster than you ever thought possible.



If you'd like to learn more about our online fitness coaching services, visit:
www.bradnewtonfitness.com/online-coaching



Final Words

I hope you enjoy these meal plans.

I've helped thousands of people reach their fitness goals, and I'm excited to be part of your journey!

I want you to feel like you always have the support you need to reach your health and fitness goals, so . . .

- ▣ If you want to join over 21,000 members with thousands of successful transformations, check out my flagship program [Ultimate Body Transformation](#).
- ▣ If you aren't sure what types of workouts are going to get you the body you really want as quickly as possible, and if you want 100% personalised training plans to help you get strong, build muscle, and avoid injury, check out my [one-on-one online fitness coaching service](#).

And again, if you have any questions or run into any issues, I will be happy to help. Please send me an email at brad@bradnewtonfitness.com and I will respond in 1-2 business days.

I look forward to hearing about your fitness transformation in 12 weeks. Submit your transformation story [here](#).

Best regards,

Brad

www.bradnewtonfitness.com